

Using expect to pass a password to ssh

Asked 14 years, 7 months ago Modified 10 years, 5 months ago Viewed 64k times



41



How can I use expect to send a password to an ssh connection.

say the password was p@ssword and the ssh command was ssh me@127.0.0.1

What would I do with expect to make it input the password when it says

me@127.0.0.1's password:

?

The proper action of using an SSH key pair isn't an option because I would have to use ssh (scp) to put the key on the server, which would ask for a password.

ssh

cygwin

expect

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asked Jan 19, 2009 at 21:12



Malfist

31.2k

61

182

269

- 1 Putting the key on the server would only have to be done once, then it would never prompt for a password again. See my answer for a link to a howto. – [rmeador](#) Jan 19, 2009 at 21:18
- 1 @malfist - why is that not an option? Generally installation & configuration of any solution is assumed, so why not make that a constraint of installation/configuration? Unless what you're doing is not above board, you should consider doing it the right way instead of designing a hack-around. – [Jason Coco](#) Jan 19, 2009 at 21:23
- 1 Then create your own controlling tty and exec ssh from there... it still sounds really fishy to me, tho. I can't think of one, non-illicit use case for this kind of "automation". – [Jason Coco](#) Jan 19, 2009 at 21:36
- 2 A legitimate reason for doing this would be if you are scripting ssh access to *network devices* which do not support certificate based login - e.g. Cisco switches. – [dunxd](#) Aug 10, 2011 at 13:51
- 3 There are other use cases. Mine is a test environment. The certificates change every time the code is reinstalled. It is a part of the test procedure. And the test must be automatic... :) – [bcelary](#) Oct 25, 2011 at 8:18

6 Answers

Sorted by:

Highest score (default)



I always used the "proper" solution, but I used expect in other situations.

79 [Here](#) I found following suggestion:

```
#!/usr/local/bin/expect
spawn sftp -b cmdFile user@yourserver.com
expect "password:"
send "shhh!\n";
interact
```



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answered Jan 19, 2009 at 21:28



max

29.1k ● 12 ● 52 ● 79

47 Thank you! Thank you for answering the question instead of telling me how I should do it. – [Malfist](#) Jan 19, 2009 at 21:38

2 @Malfist: I hate to say it, but I'm in the "explain alternate options" mindset rather than just strictly answering the question. I feel you get a better range of options that way. – [Powerlord](#) Jan 21, 2010 at 18:32

2 @R. Bemrose Enjoy trying to change the maze instead of helping navigate it. – [Kristopher Ives](#) Sep 16, 2010 at 21:49

'expect is not installed by default. Download the program and install it on the unix machine'(source linux-bsd-central.com/index.php/content/view/26). Available for download at nist.gov/el/msid/expect.cfm – [Daniel Dropik](#) May 30, 2014 at 18:31



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Would it not be easier to use public key authentication and use a key with no passphrase?

As the user on the source machine do this to make an RSA key

```
ssh-keygen -t rsa
```



Now copy ~/.ssh/id_rsa.pub to the target machine and append it to the authorized_keys file of the target user

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answered Jan 19, 2009 at 21:15



Paul Dixon

296k ● 54 ● 310 ● 348



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Your quickest way forward (unless you want to become a Tcl expert, which would be... unusual... in 2009) is probably to use `autoexpect`. Here's the man page:

<http://expect.nist.gov/example/autoexpect.man.html>



In short, fire up `autoexpect`, run your ssh session, finish up what you need to do, stop autoexpecting and then beat your keyboard over the resulting mess until it works :) I'm assuming